



MechWarrior 4: Mercenaries

The ultimate formula...

For those who haven't played the *MechWarrior* series, it's a bit of a simulator, first person, third person shooter and tactical operations game, all rolled into one. The tried and tested formula improvised through the years has made this game near-perfect. Kickstart the single-player campaign, and roam the scripted universe as a mercenary for hire. You can choose to be one of four mercenary groups, and depending on which company you choose, you have access to certain types of special Mechs, weapons and privileges. The system is pretty simple—you undertake missions that involve stuff from reconnaissance to all-out gung-ho battles. You complete a mission, you get *moolah*, and once you're done milking a planet, you



I guess you'd have to call this Black Hawk Down

hyperjump to other planets that have much more milk to, well, milk. And somewhere in the middle of those economies,

you can hire and control Lancemates, salvage and buy new tools of total destruction. All in all, by the end of *MechWarrior 4: Mercenaries*, you'll feel great; full of that I'm-oh-so-rich feeling all over your face.

The mission structure is simple, and even if you lose a mission, you can start right over. The lack of an in-mission save game can sometimes suck. The AI engine is decent and gets the job done convincingly. A Mech's paths are scripted, so play a mission a few times and you know who's coming from where and what's going to happen next.

Merc is an excellent title. It's a game that's easy to get into; pros will feel at home with the depth, and newbies won't get scared by it.

Genre: Simulation ■ **Developer:** FASA Studio ■ **Publisher:** Microsoft Game Studios ■ **System requirements:** 700 MHz CPU, 256 MB RAM, 1 GB hard disk space, 16 MB video card ■ **Price:** Rs 999 (Includes Mechwarrior 4: Black Knight) ■ **Web site:** www.fasastudio.com/games/mechwarrior4
Rating: ★★★★★



I.G.I. - 2: Covert Strike

I'm A-SASin!

It's been three years since Codemasters released Innerloop Studios' *Project IGI: I'm Going In*. The game features David Jones, a British IGI agent who executed missions involving terrorist factions. *IGI* was innovative in a few ways, including a computer-based map where you could see each and every villain roaming the great outdoors. The game did, however, have its faults, such as the AI, some clipping and texture errors, and the ability to only save between missions.

In *IGI 2*, a number of things have been added, removed, and altered; but while most of the nuisances of the first title have been ironed out, the game still leaves something to be desired.

When *Project IGI* was released, the engine was capable of some nice things, but the whole 'wow' effect was never really apparent. Also, many of the buildings were identical on the inside. In *IGI 2* too, great-looking effects are seldom obvious. Innerloop chose to use their



David Jones. A man who loves to live dangerously

own engine. It looks okay on most accounts, but it doesn't really impress as much as games based on the *Unreal II* engine. This game would be better accepted if it had some of the graphic features of the newly-released *Deus Ex 2*. It would be nice to see per-pixel lighting, shadows that play a larger role, and to be able to shoot out lights. But few games can boast as correct a set of sound effects as *IGI 2*.

At the beginning of a mission, you're shown a cutscene that tells you about what, or who, you're after. You're given a small number of weapons, and some gadgets that'll prove indispensable.

Enemies can, at times, hit you from far away, and they work really well as a team—trying to flank you, throw grenades at you, etc.

Multiplayer mode has support only for team-based combat, and when creating a game, you'll get to choose from five very diverse maps. Fighting on a tree-filled mountain one minute, and then hopping over to a Chinese temple-town the next, and with the extensive number of weapons, you should have plenty to play around with.

In most ways, *IGI 2* is a solid game, with no major downsides. However, it's not very innovative. Until a better sequel comes along, you can have a lot of fun playing *IGI 2*, both if you like challenging single player missions, or ducking it out over the Internet.

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Innerloop Studios ■ **Publisher:** Codemasters ■ **System requirements:** 700 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 32 MB video card ■ **Price:** NA ■ **Web site:** www.codemasters.com/igi2
Rating: ★★★★★